

The first settlers used the trees to build log cabins, mounted on stone foundations. Later came two-by-fours, aluminum siding, and drywall. Not to mention tarpaper and mobile homes! Even in the twenty-first century, many of the houses you will see in West Virginia are shacks—architecturally disgraceful, uncomfortable, charmless, and temporary. Compared with the sturdy Swiss chalet, the common West Virginia house is little more than a hovel.

What's more, when you look at almost any house in Switzerland, what you don't see is as telling as what you do. Before your eyes, you will find a handsome building, designed to last for centuries. You will not see any of the typical lawn decorations so popular in West Virginia. There are no rusty automobiles with their hoods up and their wheels off. There are no refrigerators lying on their backs, as if killed in battle and left to lie where they fell. Nor will you see lawnmowers, tractors, cement mixers, children's toys . . . or any of the other paraphernalia that West Virginians use to fill the empty places in their parks and gardens. No one knows why this is the case, but we will put forward a hypothesis: They are victims of abundance.

In Switzerland, the approach of winter meant many months with little access to food. It required the Swiss to think ahead, to plan for the lean months. You might think the same phenomenon would shape the culture of the mountain men of West Virginia, too. But the Mountain State is a much richer place. And it was settled—at least by Europeans—after the invention of the efficient hunting rifle. The first European settlers, tough Scots-Irishmen, found plenty of game, even in winter. They were much better armed than the “Indians” who preceded them. They found it relatively easy to feed themselves.

In fact, according to some reports, the native tribes had bad habits of their own. They didn't have to work too hard to survive, either. And when the first white men learned from the natives, not only did they pick up their skills, but they took up their insouciant attitudes.

Even today, the mountain men do not seem particularly concerned with planning for the future. When the going gets tough, the tough men of the Appalachians go hunting. Just like the Indians.

As for their miserable lodges, the settlers merely picked up the habits of the migratory hunters who preceded them. There was no need to build